Permanent Member of the UN Security Council enjoying a higher status than India. China uses the idea of its own superiority in the international pecking order to place India in a lower position or as a regional power.

It is, therefore, important for the opposite side to be aware of China's efforts in this direction and to establish a proper hierarchy from the very outset of the negotiation. The trick is to make it clear to the Chinese side at the outset that the negotiations are between two equal parties. It is helpful to quote the Five Principles of Peaceful Co-existence back to the Chinese from time to time to make this point. The Chinese will find it hard to refute that. Establishing parity in talks with China is, therefore, critical.

One of the favourite moves in the Chinese playbook is to play upon the emotions of the Indian interlocutor. The Chinese head of delegation will indulge in flattery by telling her or him that they are an 'old friend' (*lao pengyou* in Chinese) of China. This is intended to make the opposite negotiator not only feel special but also obligated to be sympathetic to the Chinese. It almost always succeeds. The trick works best on Chinese home ground. The Indian interlocutor is told that the venue for the talks or the banquet has been specially selected for her or him, or that the Chinese leadership knows how influential the individual is in her or his government, or that the interlocutor speaks the Chinese language just like a Chinese. In rare cases, they 'break' protocol by granting a higher level of meeting than is usually warranted, to make the Indian interlocutor feel as if she or he is highly valued by the Chinese side.

The Indian negotiator is also flattered if the Chinese bestow a Chinese name upon her or him, usually consisting of Chinese characters with exotic meanings that are usually not used by the Chinese themselves. The Chinese hospitality can be beguiling and, often, intoxicating as well, and the idea is to